

THE FIRST CHAPTER, FREE

Sit still enough to hear it

Essays on the tiredness of performing a life,
and the way home to contentment

soulsensis



CHAPTER 1

A fraction of who I am

We live in a world where people are habituated to not listen to their truest calling.

Breaking out of the script is literally just breaking out of the habit of not listening to yourself.

Perception is key

I turned thirty recently. Like most people hitting that milestone, I scrolled through LinkedIn and Instagram and felt the dread wash over me. Everyone my age looked further along, better positioned, more accomplished, and I was measuring my progress against theirs as if we were running the same race. I caught myself spiralling into self-hatred for not being where I thought I should be. And then it hit me. Their goals are not mine. Their path is theirs, and mine is mine. If I keep comparing, I self-combust, pouring all that energy into hating who I am instead of becoming who I am meant to be.

That is perception. And it is the single greatest indicator of the quality of your life.

Think of hot and cold. They sit on the same spectrum, and which one you feel depends entirely on where you are standing. Someone who grew up in the Arctic calls a ten degree day mild. Someone from Darwin reaches for a jumper. Same day, two truths. Duality is a concept we import into conversations to aid understanding, but it is not fixed. It is entirely subject to the perceiver.

The world operates on this principle. For every event that happens to you, there are interpretations available. When a relationship ends, whether with an employer, a business or a life partner, you can see it as a gift or as an event of significant sorrow, and there is no right or wrong, for you will always be right. But how you think about it dictates your moods and motives, and the actions those moods and motives trigger.

I've lived this. Every job I lost led to a better one, and to new adventures I never would have chosen. A breakup I thought would break me led me to the love of my life, and to our baby.

Simple things. You can't see them in the painful moment. But if you can look past the pain and see the beauty in it, do it, and do it earlier each time.

So start perceiving everything that occurs to you as happening for you. Something shifts immediately. The victim mindset has no choice but to disappear, and with it, all resistance to life dissolves. Resistance is simply the friction between your expectations and what is actually happening. Nothing more.

And notice how much of the world runs on the opposite. The news, the feeds, the constant talk of collapse. If enough people believe the world is going to fall apart, would it not be logical to assume their actions move it towards that very eventuality? Perception is not just private. It is collective.

Growing up academically focused, I missed the life skills that actually matter, the ones that allow you to work with people, not just outperform them. That linear model breeds comparison, and comparison produces either a deflation or an ego boost, neither of which is real. It is all a mirage. I do not compare myself to others anymore. If comparison arises, the only permissible version is this: compare yourself to who you were yesterday, not to who someone else is today. Comparison, in any sustained form, is the thief of joy.

To make this concrete: being compassionate with an irate driver tailgating you and simply letting them pass. Stepping aside for a stranger walking head on without expecting them to move first. These are not grand spiritual gestures. They are micro-decisions of perception, made in real time, that compound into a fundamentally different way of moving through the world.

So what do you do when life hands you something you did not ask for? The first instinct is resistance. That is human. But on the other side of that resistance is something grounding and deeply peaceful. You sit down with your own heart and mind and ask a single question: how can I perceive this as happening for me, not to me? In that moment you realise you are the thinker of the thoughts, the experiencer of the experiences. You do not lose yourself in the events. And underneath the rubble of whatever has arrived uninvited, there is always gold. You just need the patience to dig. That gold is your soul.

Many of us complain about what arrives, demanding apples or oranges when a lemon has been delivered. Make lemonade. Complaining leads you nowhere, because you will reject every sign that is moving you in your unique direction.

Society will try to impose fear on you. Its script tells you that you need to be this, that and the other, while your soul knows it is destined to travel a path no one has travelled before. Accept the script, and confusion and escapism, to numb the pain of the mismatch, become inevitable. A poor quality meal served on a gold platter is still a poor quality meal. There is no disguising your truth from yourself.

So perceive every event in a way that moves you forward. A job loss becomes the time to finally do what you have put off for so long. Even a death. Be human. Cry, grieve, share the sorrow. Then bring yourself back, and perhaps be the one who organises the funeral with competence, despite the tears, so that you awaken to your own inner strength. If you were never someone who could do this, doing it can be deeply liberating.

None of this means skipping the pain. The emotions must be felt, because otherwise the bottle shop and the local dealer keep

their business. Numbness is a cheap sell. Interpreting your own life with optimism is a harder sell. But with time, patience and conviction, it leads to a life not marred by peaks of happiness and troughs of depression, but one of deep peace and steady contentment.

Here's something to try tonight. Take one thing that went wrong this week. Write it at the top of a page, and underneath, one line: how is this happening for me? Keep going until you find the gold.

And contentment, it turns out, is infectious. When you live in this state, something shifts in the room. You stop performing for the world and start leading it, not by force, but by example. That is the power of perception. And it was always yours to claim.

We weren't meant to be living the way we do

We weren't meant to be living the way we do. Most of us feel it. And most of us feel we don't have a choice. But we make choices all day, every day. The real question is whether we are the ones making them.

But when you are handed one path (go to school, go to college, get a degree, then do work that doesn't fulfil you for the rest of your life), you don't know what to do when that path stops working. So you start to question it. There is no shortage of voices telling you that life is shit and it is your fault. Far fewer ask whether the path was flawed to begin with. Between the numbness and the overstimulation, most of us never get quiet enough to ask the questions that would set us free.

If the path was not built in our favour, that is no reason to give up on greatness. It just means we go in with our eyes open.

It's like walking onto a tennis court knowing your opponent was allowed to take performance-enhancing drugs. You can still play. You just stop blaming your own legs for every lost point. Knowing that lets you play to your advantage instead of blindly. And once you accept that the world was not built around your spiritual wellbeing, a lot of what used to confuse you starts to make sense.

When I watch the news, a lot of it feels less like information and more like programming, built to keep me reacting. Fear, survival, frustration. What none of it tells you is that life can be peaceful. It can be still and tranquil. And I suspect the noise is a big part of that strange feeling so many of us carry, that something in this world is out of place and no one can quite put a finger on it.

Once you see this clearly, you can't go back. You can't trick yourself into unknowing what you know.

So you start to pull back, and your decisions start to look different from everyone else's. But here is the trap: doing the opposite of the masses is still letting the masses decide for you. Contrarianism is just another script. The point was never to be against the system. The point is to be deliberate. So pick your battles. Before any big decision, ask one question: is this mine, or was it handed to me? If it's yours, keep it, even if everyone else made the same choice. If it was handed to you, look at it twice. Most of the time your heart knows the answer before you finish asking. Listen to it. That is how you become the one making the choices again.

You do not get what you want

There are mornings I wake under a weight I can't name and can't shake. It sits underneath everything, telling me something in my life is off. And strangely, what makes it worse is that I know I am the one who made it this way.

If I know that I am the one causing it, then why don't I just change it? Why do I still choose the suffering, even this quiet kind? I keep returning to this question because my heart knows it is the most honest one I can ask. When I sit with it, the answer is plain: I am allowing myself to be stuck, looping in thought and, often, doing nothing at all. To ease the feeling of being trapped, I reach for things I think I want, knowing full well they lead me nowhere. It is an escape from what is real in my heart.

So I do nothing to fix it. I cry out for someone to help, and I forget what I have come to believe: no one else can do the inner work for me. The shift in perspective I need has to come from me. The people I love can stand beside me, and reaching out to them, or to a doctor or counsellor, is worth doing, for me and for you if your mornings feel like this too. But they can't make that shift for me, and neither will waiting on circumstances to change. Underneath it all, I have found, is too much wanting. On these days I come back to one line:

You do not get what you want, you get what you are.

When I wake with that dread, call it depression or anxiety, I desperately want it gone. I've noticed that the desperate wanting is part of what traps me. It makes not being depressed the most important thing in the world, and that makes the gap between me and a life of freedom and joy feel wider than it is.

The more I tell myself "I don't want to feel this", the heavier it sits. I've noticed that when I keep thinking about not wanting something, I'm really just keeping that "thing" in my mind, and the longer I hold it there, the bigger it gets. So, as I see it, I am making my depression, anxiety and dread sit heavier because I keep wanting to change, wanting to get out of it, rather than doing what is simplest: accepting exactly where I am right now, and taking the next action that follows naturally.

Forcing change doesn't work. The tighter I grip, the further the thing I want seems to move away. I've noticed the opposite too. When I loosen my grip, what I was chasing sometimes drifts towards me more easily. Funnily enough, it usually happens once I have forgotten about it and stopped making it so important. Importance is the key. When I make anything hugely important, a thing, a feeling, a state of mind, I am telling myself there is a gap between who I am and the version of me who already has it. And that is what the line means to me. Wanting is a way of being the one who lacks. I don't get what I want. I get what I am, and while I am wanting, what I am is lacking. I learn this, forget it, and learn it again, more often than I can count.

When I suffer, it is rarely the situation itself that hurts most, but the importance I place on getting out of it, or on getting into some better state. Fighting it sends me reaching for something to numb it, and there is always something within reach. The numbing costs more than the original pain, and I know that deep down, yet I still find it hard to stop.

So what helps me, before I get to that point, is to stop fighting the situation and let it be what it is. Not forcing the bad thing to feel good, but asking what it might be here to show me. Then the day starts to feel like it is happening for me rather than to me. When I choose to see a situation as only a problem, I now count

it as a wrong move, like in chess: the rules are fixed, but the move is mine.

Whatever arises, I can tell myself it is here to wake me up, to stretch how I see. That way, hard days become small stress tests, and I grow through them. Instead of forcing outcomes, I try to hold a quiet trust that what is mine will come in its time. Trust is the opposite of wanting. It already lives as though the gap has closed.

Some mornings my inner child screams for someone to fix my situation, for anyone at all to make things easier and hand me what I decided I wanted. But in my experience, the easing has to be done by the one who is suffering. Being rescued would take away the very work I grow through.

I have a daughter now, a life, a vision for my business, and living through the lens of my inner child does not work anymore. I cannot let the child dictate my moves. The child can stay, but it takes the back seat. The decisions that matter now fall to me, the man, present and grounded. Becoming a father has meant re-parenting myself: gently but firmly saying no to the part of me that is still waiting for a saviour. On the heavy mornings I still feel the weight. But I have stopped begging it to leave. I get up, I make my daughter's breakfast, and I try to be the man I want her to have, before I feel like him. You do not get what you want. You get what you are.

The receptiveness I was waiting for

There is a particular kind of tiredness that lives at the edge of a life that has not yet committed to itself. It is not the tiredness of the body. It is the tiredness of waiting. Waiting for the right moment, the right reception, the right sign that one is finally allowed to be who one already is. I have come to understand that this waiting is the wound. Not the thing waited for, but the waiting itself. And the only way through is to stop.

For a long time, I thought the things I was reaching for outside me were missing pieces. The acceptance, the pride, the receptiveness of others, the affirmation that I was enough. But the reaching itself is the deficit. The acceptance and pride I wanted from others were the acceptance and pride I had not yet given myself. When this lands, it lands quietly. The world does not change. The inner posture does. And from that changed posture, everything else slowly rearranges.

Most of us carry some version of this: the need to be received before we will let ourselves be. It shows up in marriages, in careers, in creative work. The person waits for the partner to soften. The professional waits for the institution to validate. The writer waits for the audience to confirm that what they are writing is worth writing. And in each case, the waiting is the trap. And even when the thing waited for arrives, it does not land, because the one waiting has not yet accepted themselves. The partner softens and it is not enough. The praise comes and it is gone by morning.

For years I have chosen wanting over becoming the person I want to be. Wanting is a softer place than becoming, and the mind knows this. The mind will negotiate, postpone, reframe. It will tell you that the conditions are not yet right, that the

moment is not yet ripe, that the other person, the other circumstance, the other version of you must first arrive. None of it is true. The conditions are never right. The moment is the only moment. And the person who has to arrive is the one already standing here.

I do not need to live the way I have been living. The small consumptions that mark the day and lead nowhere, the real work traded for smaller, easier rewards. None of it is what I am after. What I am after is far deeper than any of it. I can feel the experience of life I want, and it is not in the small loops. It is in the long building of something that means something.

The mind cannot force this. I have tried to think my way into accepting myself, and it never works. Acceptance is a movement of the heart, not a verdict of the mind. The mind can recognise the conclusion. It cannot generate the feeling. The feeling comes when the heart is allowed to speak and the mind, for once, is willing to listen. I will let the heart speak to the mind without fear and without resistance. I am tired of waiting.

So no more. No more chasing. No more waiting, especially for the receptiveness of another soul, because waiting for someone else's soul to open is a signal that I am still far from my own. The receptiveness I have been seeking outside me is the receptiveness I have been refusing to offer myself. Once that is seen, it cannot be unseen. The work is to do things from the heart, without lying to myself, without hiding, without quietly managing an image of who I am meant to be.

I am proud of where I am. I almost gave up on the dream that brought me here. What I was waiting for was to let myself have the things I deserved. I believed I had to work hard to earn what I wanted, so I worked hard, and because you don't get what you

want, you get who you are, I ended up with nothing to show for it. I was stuck for a long time, knowing exactly why and unable to do anything about it, until I made one positive decision to change. It is better now. I was stationary for so long that stationary started to feel like a destination. It was not. It was a holding pattern, a place to wait while I worked out whether I was willing to be the person the dream required. I am willing now. The pride I feel is not a performance. It is the quiet recognition that I have moved, that the movement was harder than it looked from outside, and that the next movement is mine to make. I let myself have the joy, selfishly, because if I do not give it to myself I will go on looking for it in other people, and the deficit will go on running my life.

The promise I am making is small and specific. I will listen to my heart and act in line with it. And I will give without asking to be received, because asking for something back is only waiting in another form. Salary, recognition, reciprocation, none of these are the point. That is the standard I have set for myself. I have not always lived up to it. I am beginning to see that living up to it is not as hard as I have been telling myself.

What I am building is not complicated. The thoughts have already been laid out. The work has already been done in the writing of it, sentence by sentence, day by day. What remains is the next step, and the question of whether I take it now or stay the person who never quite does. Once you know what you have to do, there is no going back to not knowing. You either go all in, or you keep paying for the distance between what you know and how you live.

There is nothing to wait for. The receptiveness, the acceptance, the pride, all of it is available the moment I am willing to give it to myself. So here is the practice. Name the one

thing you are waiting for someone else to give you: their approval, their reply, their softening. Then ask what it would look like to give it to yourself today, in one act no one else needs to see. Do that. Then do the next one. The alternative, the staying, the chasing, the waiting, has already shown what it costs.

I am tired of being a fraction of who I am. So I am no longer going to be one.



That was the first chapter.

There are five more, and the whole way home. The book is being finished.

soulsensis.com/book.html

The first to hear when it is out: join the letters

This is book one of three. Book two, A lighthouse does not try, comes next.

soulsensis writes essays, and plays the piano.